

DWARIKA PRASAD MAMGAIN, 85
KRISHNA DEVI, 76
Baingwadi village, *Pauri Garhwal*

"OUR HEART DOESN'T ALLOW IT"

A short walk uphill in Baingwadi village and there stands a 150-year-old house with thick stone walls and a wooden veranda that looks over deserted terraced fields. This is where Dwarika Prasad Mamgain, a retired government school principal, and his wife, Krishna Devi, pass their days quietly. He reads his books and keeps an eye on the small clutch of fruit trees outside his house. She moves slowly through the house, cooking, cleaning, and tending to her little kitchen garden, now full of flowering shrubs. Her legs are not what they used to be, and she has difficulty walking.

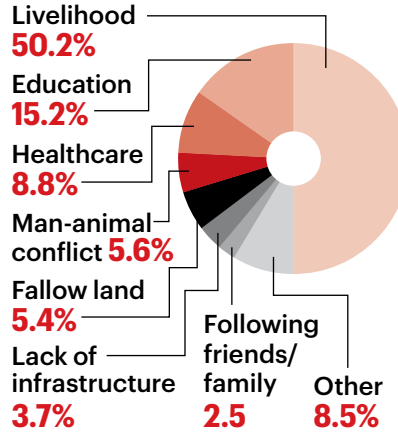
Their son works in Delhi and visits when he can. He often urges them to move to the city, where medical help is readily available and life would be easier. The couple has heard the argument many times but never seriously considered it. "Our heart does not allow it," says Mamgain. They prefer the familiar, even if it means long stretches of silence and no immediate support if anything goes wrong. Their presence also keeps the home from joining the many locked ones around them.

the exodus has hollowed out entire communities. A 2022 survey had underlined the severity of the problem; more than half of those who left cited lack of jobs as the main reason. Another 15 per cent moved out because of poor educational opportunities, while nearly 9 per cent left in search of better healthcare (the latest 2025 report only had details of inward migration).

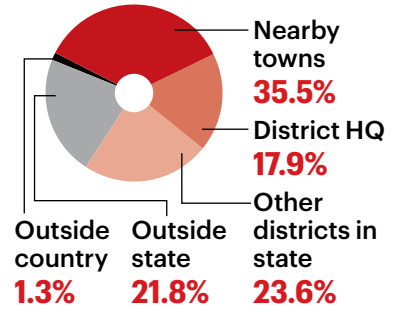
Despite the bleak narrative, the state administration claims there are signs of a turnaround. The state migration commission, in its latest report in August, says 6,268 people have returned to their native villages in the last few years, many setting up small farms, homestays or food ventures. Officials describe it as "reverse migration", though experts point out that the numbers remain too small to change the overall picture.

And even when people do return, they are not always satisfied. Seven months ago, Mukesh Arya, 28, came back after four years of working as a cook in Dubai. "There, the money was good, but the peace was missing," he says. His elder brother still works in Dubai in the hotel business; the younger one is in Mumbai. When he

WHY THEY LEFT...



...AND TO WHERE



Source: *2022 Migration Commission report*

came back, Mukesh was determined to stay. He set up a small kirana shop, but before long found himself joining a torchlit protest march from Pilkhi to Akhori, demanding better health and education facilities. The nearest hospital is a 43 km drive to Pilkhi, and it's at best a primary health centre. The major facility is the army base hospital in Srinagar, and for serious cases, families must rush to Dehradun. Facilities like blood banks or an ultrasound are absent in the entire region. The irony is not lost on him. He had returned home seeking peace, only to fight for the most basic of rights.

Like him, Deepak Nautiyal too had come seeking peace when he left his corporate job in Gurugram to return to his ancestral village of Kyark in Pauri district. His stone-and-mud home, perched on a gentle rise overlooking a valley in Uttarakhand, looks like something out of a travel brochure. Warm light spills from the large windows, fruit trees are blooming in the courtyard and terraces of green as far as the eye can see. In 2020, when he left his corporate job to return, many thought he was making a mistake. At 45, he was well set in the corporate world. But Nautiyal chose